COLOSSIANS · STUDY 03 OF 12

Colossians 1:15–23

The Savior of the Gospel

Christ Is All — A Study of Colossians

Small Group Bible Study Series · NASB95

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① Text	② Devotional	③ Commentary	④ Self-Study Guide
Foundation	Personal preparation	Teacher / leader preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	*All group members*	*Teacher / leader*	*Small group*

⑤ *Application closes each study and draws from all sections above.*

Time guide: about 30 minutes — Devotional 4 · Commentary 15 · Discussion 8 · Application 3.

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① BIBLICAL TEXT

Colossians 1:15–23 · New American Standard Bible (NASB95)

1:15 *He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation.*

16 *For by Him all things were created, both in the heavens and on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or dominions or rulers or authorities—all things have been created through Him and for Him.*

17 *He is before all things, and in Him all things hold together.*

18 *He is also head of the body, the church; and He is the beginning, the firstborn from the dead, so that He Himself will come to have first place in everything.*

19 *For it was the Father's good pleasure for all the fullness to dwell in Him,*

20 *and through Him to reconcile all things to Himself, having made peace through the blood of His cross; through Him, I say, whether things on earth or things in heaven.*

21 *And although you were formerly alienated and hostile in mind, engaged in evil deeds,*

22 *yet He has now reconciled you in His fleshly body through death, in order to present you before Him holy and blameless and beyond reproach—*

23 *if indeed you continue in the faith firmly established and steadfast, and not moved away from the hope of the gospel that you have heard, which was proclaimed in all creation under heaven, and of which I, Paul, was made a minister.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · Drawn from the outline of this study

Who Is This Jesus?

> *“so that He Himself will come to have first place in everything”*
> *— Colossians 1:18 (NASB95)*

Every age asks the same question: who is Jesus? The false teachers in Colossae had an answer. He was important, perhaps, but He was one spiritual power among many, a step on a ladder toward God. Paul's answer is one of the most breathtaking passages in all of Scripture. Jesus is the image of the invisible God. He made everything, including the angels the false teachers revered, and He holds everything together right now.

This same Jesus is Head of the Church and the first to rise from the dead never to die again. All the fullness of God dwells in Him. And this exalted Lord came near. He made peace through the blood of His cross, and He reconciled people like us, once alienated and hostile in mind, in His real body through a real death.

Why did He do it? To present us before Him holy and blameless. Reconciliation is His gift, settled at the cross. Being presented complete is the goal He is working toward in us, as we continue steady in the faith and are not moved away from the hope of the gospel.

For reflection

1. Is there any area of your life where Jesus does not yet have "first place"?
2. How does knowing that Christ holds "all things" together change the way you face this week?
3. What might it look like for you to stay "firmly established and steadfast" in the hope of the gospel?

He is before all things, and in Him all things hold together, including you.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **The passage teaches:** Jesus Christ is supreme over creation as its image-bearing Creator and Sustainer, supreme over the Church as its Head and the firstborn from the dead, and supreme in reconciliation, having made peace through His cross so that believers, already reconciled, may be presented holy and blameless as they continue in the faith.

Outline

I. Christ and Creation (1:15–17)
- A. He Is the Picture of God (1:15a)
- B. He Has Priority over Creation (1:15b)
- C. He Is the Creator of the Universe (1:16)
- D. He Is the Sustainer of the Universe (1:17)

II. Christ and the Church (1:18–20)
- A. He Is the Head of the Body (1:18a)
- B. He Is the Firstborn from the Dead (1:18b)
- C. He Is the Fullness of God (1:19)
- D. He Is the Reconciler Through the Cross (1:20)

III. Christ and the Cross (1:21–23)
- A. The Requirement of the Cross (1:21)
- B. The Remedy of the Cross (1:22a)
- C. The Reason for the Cross (1:22b)
- D. The Condition for Being Presented (1:23)

Introduction

Paul has just spoken of "the kingdom of His beloved Son, in whom we have redemption" (1:13–14). Now he tells us who that Son is. Against a teaching that made Christ one link in a chain of spiritual powers between God and man, Paul gives one of the greatest statements of Christ's deity and supremacy found anywhere in the Bible. Many believe verses 15–20 may have been an early hymn of the Church, but whatever its form, the content is clear: Christ is first in creation, first in the Church, and the only way of reconciliation.

I. Christ and Creation (1:15–17)

A. He Is the Picture of God (1:15a)

"He is the image of the invisible God." How can anyone be the image (*eikōn*) of a God who is invisible? An image implies both representation and manifestation. When man was created in the image of God, that image included qualities like holiness and righteousness, which cannot be seen with the eye. But the Son became visible. In Him the invisible God has shown us what He is like.

> *“And the Word became flesh, and dwelt among us, and we saw His glory, glory as of the only begotten from the Father, full of grace and truth.”*
>
> — John 1:14 (NASB95)

> *“Jesus said to him, “Have I been so long with you, and yet you have not come to know Me, Philip? He who has seen Me has seen the Father; how can you say, ‘Show us the Father’?”*
>
> — John 14:9 (NASB95)

B. He Has Priority over Creation (1:15b)

"The firstborn of all creation." Some groups seize on this phrase to argue that Christ was the first being God created. That reading collides with the very next verse, which says all things were created by Him. "Firstborn" (*prōtotokos*) speaks of **priority and preeminence**, the rank and rights of the heir. God said of David, who was the youngest of his brothers, "I also shall make him My firstborn, the highest of the kings of the earth" (Ps. 89:27). The title is about status, not origin.

It helps to compare "firstborn" with "only begotten" (*monogenēs*, John 3:16). "Only begotten" stresses **uniqueness**. Isaac is called Abraham's "only begotten son" (Heb. 11:17), even though Abraham had other sons (Gen. 25:1–2). Isaac was unique as the son of promise through Sarah. Jesus is the unique Son, and He is the Firstborn who holds first rank over all creation.

C. He Is the Creator of the Universe (1:16)

"For by Him all things were created." The Son is the Creator of all things (John 1:3; Heb. 1:2). Paul then sweeps through the whole of creation:

- **In the heavens and on earth.** There is nothing "out there" that lies beyond His authority.
- **Visible and invisible.** Even what we cannot see is His handiwork and under His control.
- **Thrones, dominions, rulers, authorities.** These describe the ranks of the angelic world. The list is not exhaustive, but it covers the angelic sphere in a general way.

That last point would have hit the Colossian heresy hard. The very angels they were tempted to worship (2:18) were created by Christ. They belong in the same category as sticks and stones: creatures. Then Paul adds, "all things have been created **through Him** and **for Him**." He is the agent of creation and its goal. Compare what Paul says of the Lord in Romans 11:36: "For from Him and through Him and to Him are all things." What is said of God is said of Christ.

D. He Is the Sustainer of the Universe (1:17)

"He is before all things, and in Him all things hold together." Someone might ask, "What if creation runs down, or rebels, or flies apart?" The answer is that the One who made the universe still upholds it. The verb (*synistēmi*, perfect tense) means to stand together, to cohere. The universe is not held together by chance or by impersonal forces alone. It holds together in Christ.

II. Christ and the Church (1:18–20)

A. He Is the Head of the Body (1:18a)

"He is also head of the body, the church." Here "the church" is the universal body of all believers. Every believer is baptized by the Holy Spirit into that body the moment he believes (1 Cor. 12:13). This work of the Spirit began on the Day of Pentecost (Acts 1:5; 2:1–4; 11:15–16). The Church is "neither Jew nor Greek" (Gal. 3:28) but a new creation of God, "one new man" (Eph. 2:15). It is the "mystery" not made known in earlier generations (Eph. 3:4–6; Col. 1:26). And Christ is its Head, its source of life, authority, and direction.

B. He Is the Firstborn from the Dead (1:18b)

"And He is the beginning, the firstborn from the dead." Others had been raised from the dead before, but they all died again. Christ was the first to rise to resurrection life, never to die again. His resurrection marked the defeat of death and the one who held its power:

> *"Therefore, since the children share in flesh and blood, He Himself likewise also partook of the same, that through death He might render powerless him who had the power of death, that is, the devil, and might free those who through fear of death were subject to slavery all their lives."*
>
> — Hebrews 2:14–15 (NASB95)

> *"For as in Adam all die, so also in Christ all will be made alive. But each in his own order: Christ the first fruits, after that those who are Christ's at His coming,"*
>
> — 1 Corinthians 15:22–23 (NASB95)

The purpose is stated plainly: "so that He Himself will come to have first place in everything." First in creation, first in resurrection, first in the Church, first in everything.

C. He Is the Fullness of God (1:19)

"For it was the Father's good pleasure for all the fullness to dwell in Him." The false teachers likely used "fullness" (*plērōma*) for the whole range of spiritual powers between God and man. Paul says the fullness is not spread out among angels; it dwells in Christ. The verb (*katoikeō*) means to settle down and be at home permanently. All that the Father is, the Son is. Paul will say it again even more plainly in 2:9.

D. He Is the Reconciler Through the Cross (1:20)

"And through Him to reconcile all things to Himself, having made peace through the blood of His cross." Paul obviously does not mean that everyone will be saved. Only those who believe in Christ are reconciled to God and receive eternal life (John 3:16, 36). "All things" refers to the whole created order being brought back under its rightful Head. The earth itself will be redeemed and restored to its intended purpose (Rom. 8:19–22). Those who refuse the salvation Christ secured will face judgment. And all of this is accomplished "through the blood of His cross," His sacrificial death.

Notice also the direction of reconciliation. It is man who is reconciled to God, not God to man. God did not need to change; we did.

III. Christ and the Cross (1:21–23)

A. The Requirement of the Cross (1:21)

"And although you were formerly alienated and hostile in mind, engaged in evil deeds." This is the condition of every person before Christ: alienated in relationship, hostile in attitude, and evil in action. Christ reconciles sinners, not righteous people. No one is too sinful to receive it, and no one is too righteous to need it.

B. The Remedy of the Cross (1:22a)

"Yet He has now reconciled you." The atonement is presented in Scripture from three directions:

- **Redemption** is the sin-ward aspect: the price paid to free us (Matt. 20:28).
- **Reconciliation** is the man-ward aspect: the barrier removed so we are brought back to God (2 Cor. 5:18–20).
- **Propitiation** is the God-ward aspect: God's justice satisfied (1 John 2:2).

And notice the means: "in His fleshly body through death." Gnostics, take notice! It was not a phantom body, and it was not a mere man. The eternal Son died in a real body of flesh.

C. The Reason for the Cross (1:22b)

"In order to present you before Him holy and blameless and beyond reproach." These words can describe the believer's **position** before God, which is already perfect in Christ (Rom. 8:1; Eph. 1:4), or the believer's **condition**, his actual spiritual maturity. God envisions both for His children: holy and blameless before Him (Eph. 1:4) and conformed to the image of His Son (Rom. 8:29).

In this context Paul appears to be speaking of the believer's spiritual condition and of a future presentation. Paul uses the same verb, "present" (*paristēmi*), in 1:28 for presenting every believer "complete in Christ," and in 2 Corinthians 11:2 of presenting the church as a pure virgin. This presentation looks ahead to the Judgment Seat of Christ, where believers' lives and works will be evaluated (2 Cor. 5:10). Not every believer will be presented in this way. The letters to the churches in Revelation 2–3 make clear that not every believer is an overcomer.

D. The Condition for Being Presented (1:23)

"If indeed you continue in the faith firmly established and steadfast, and not moved away from the hope of the gospel that you have heard." Here is a crucial verse, and it needs to be read carefully.

- **The "if" clause is a first class condition** (*ei ge*), which assumes the condition for the sake of argument. Paul expresses confidence that the Colossians will continue, though that is his expectation and earnest hope, not a guarantee about every individual.
- **The condition modifies "present," not "reconciled."** Reconciliation is already accomplished: "He has now reconciled you" (v.22). That is settled, past, and

permanent. The condition attaches to the purpose clause: being presented holy, blameless, and beyond reproach.

- **Paul is not making eternal salvation conditional on perseverance.** One does not have to live a perfect life, or even a persevering life, to be reconciled to God. Remember John 3:16. But believers do need to continue in the faith, grounded and steadfast, in order to be presented in this way at the Judgment Seat of Christ.

Free Grace interpreters such as Joseph Dillow, in *The Reign of the Servant Kings*, have argued at length that verses like this one concern the believer's future reward and approval, not whether he possesses eternal life. That is the reading followed here: the gift is secure; the presentation is the prize.

Paul closes the section by saying that this gospel "was proclaimed in all creation under heaven, and of which I, Paul, was made a minister." That had obviously not happened in the literal sense of every individual. Some take it as a deliberate overstatement to show how far the gospel had already gone. Others understand it to mean that the gospel had gone to all without distinction, to every kind of people, though not yet to all without exception. Either way, Paul's point is that the Colossians' gospel was not a local novelty but the one worldwide message.

Conclusion

Who is Jesus? He is the image of the invisible God, the Firstborn over creation, the Creator of all things, including the angels, and the One in whom all things hold together. He is the Head of the Church, the first to rise from the dead, the dwelling place of all the fullness of God, and the One who made peace through the blood of His cross.

If He is all that, then He is enough. We do not need to climb a ladder of angels or add a secret knowledge to reach God. Through His death in a real body, believers are already reconciled. The question now is whether we will continue firmly established and steadfast, so that He may present us holy, blameless, and beyond reproach in that day.

Lord, thank You.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Grammar and parsing: Blue Letter Bible. Sources cited selectively: STR (Strong's), THAY (Thayer's), ATR (A. T. Robertson), VINE (Vine's), MRV (Vincent's), LXX (Septuagint usage).

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
v.15	**εἰκών** *image*	**G1504** *eikōn* Nom. Fem. Sg.	**THAY:** an image, likeness; implies representation and manifestation. **VINE:** not a faint copy but the very revelation of the original. **Significance:** Christ makes the invisible God visible (John 14:9).
v.15	**ἀόρατος** *invisible*	**G517** *aoratos* Gen. Masc. Sg.	**STR:** unseen, invisible. **Significance:** The God no one can see is revealed in the Son.
v.15	**πρωτότοκος** *firstborn*	**G4416** *prōtotokos* Nom. Masc. Sg.	**LXX:** used of David's preeminence (Ps. 89:27) and of Israel's status (Exod. 4:22). **VINE:** expresses priority to and preeminence over creation, not being the first created. **Significance:** A title of rank, not origin; v.16 says He created all things.
v.16	**κτίζω** *created*	**G2936** *ktizō* Aor. Pass. Ind. 3rd Sg. / Perf. Pass. Ind. 3rd Sg.	**ATR:** the aorist views the act of creation; the perfect (*ektistai*) its abiding result. **Significance:** All things, including angelic ranks, were made by, through, and for Christ.
v.17	**συνίστημι** *hold together*	**G4921** *synistēmi* Perf. Act. Ind. 3rd Sg.	**THAY:** to stand together, cohere. **MRV:** Christ is the principle of cohesion in the universe. **Significance:** The Creator still sustains creation moment by moment.
v.18	**κεφαλή** *head*	**G2776** *kephalē* Nom. Fem. Sg.	**VINE:** used of Christ as source of life and authority for the Church. **Significance:** The Church draws its life and direction from Christ alone (cf. 2:19).
v.18	**πρωτεύω** *have first place*	**G4409** *prōteuō* Pres. Act. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Sg.	**STR:** to be first, have preeminence. Occurs only here in the NT. **Significance:** The goal of the whole passage: Christ first in everything.
v.19	**πλήρωμα** *fullness*	**G4138** *plērōma* Acc. Neut. Sg.	**MRV:** possibly a term of the false teachers for the totality of divine powers. **Significance:** The fullness is not distributed among angels; it dwells in Christ (2:9).
v.19	**κατοικέω** *dwell*	**G2730** *katoikeō* Aor. Act. Inf.	**THAY:** to settle down, dwell permanently. **Significance:** Deity is permanently at home in Christ, not a temporary visitor.

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
v.20	**ἀποκαταλλάσσω** *reconcile*	**G604** *apokatallassō* Aor. Act. Inf. (v.20) / Aor. Act. Ind. 3rd Sg. (v.22)	**VINE:** to reconcile completely; the double prefix intensifies the idea. **Significance:** Reconciliation is God's completed work through the cross; man is reconciled to God.
v.21	**ἀπαλλοτριόω** *alienated*	**G526** *apallotrioō* Perf. Pass. Ptc. Acc. Masc. Pl.	**STR:** to estrange, make a stranger of. **Significance:** The perfect stresses a settled state of estrangement before Christ.
v.22	**παρίστημι** *present*	**G3936** *paristēmi* Aor. Act. Inf.	**VINE:** to place beside, present; used of presentation before a judge or king. **Significance:** Points to a future presentation (cf. 1:28; 2 Cor. 11:2), linked with the Judgment Seat of Christ.
v.22	**ἀνέγκλητος** *beyond reproach*	**G410** *anegklētos* Acc. Masc. Pl.	**THAY:** unaccused, that cannot be called to account. **Significance:** A legal word: nothing to charge against the believer at the presentation.
v.23	**ἐπιμένω** *continue*	**G1961** *epimenō* Pres. Act. Ind. 2nd Pl.	**ATR:** with *ei ge*, a first class condition, assumed true for the argument. **Significance:** The condition governs being presented, not having been reconciled.

Grammar key — Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. Verb Mood: Ind. · Imp. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Review prompt	From the commentary
What does "firstborn of all creation" mean?	Priority and preeminence (rank of the heir), not that Christ was created; cf. Ps. 89:27.
How does "only begotten" differ from "firstborn"?	"Only begotten" stresses uniqueness (Isaac, Heb. 11:17); "firstborn" stresses rank.
Why mention thrones, dominions, rulers, and authorities?	The angelic ranks revered by the false teachers were created by Christ; they are creatures.
Name the three aspects of the atonement.	Redemption (sin-ward), reconciliation (man-ward), propitiation (God-ward).
What does the "if" in 1:23 modify?	"Present" (v.22b), not "reconciled" (v.22a); reconciliation is already done.

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. How does verse 16 answer those who say "firstborn" means Christ was the first created being?

> **Leader's answer:** Verse 16 says all things were created by Him, through Him, and for Him, including all invisible powers. If He created all things, He cannot Himself be a created thing. "Firstborn" denotes rank, as with David (Ps. 89:27).

2. Why would Paul emphasize that Christ created the angelic ranks?

> **Leader's answer:** The false teachers promoted the worship of angels as mediators (2:18). If Christ created thrones, dominions, rulers, and authorities, they are His creatures, and no believer needs them to reach God.

3. Does "reconcile all things" (v.20) teach that everyone will be saved? Explain.

> **Leader's answer:** No. Only believers are reconciled to God and receive eternal life (John 3:16, 36). "All things" refers to the created order restored under its rightful Head; those who reject Christ face judgment.

4. Why does Paul stress "in His fleshly body through death" (v.22)?

> **Leader's answer:** To refute the error that Christ had no real body (Docetism) and to show that a real death in a real body accomplished reconciliation.

5. According to this study, what is conditional in verses 22–23, and what is not?

> **Leader's answer:** Reconciliation is not conditional; "He has now reconciled you" is complete. What is conditional is being presented holy, blameless, and beyond reproach, which depends on continuing firmly established in the faith. That presentation is linked with the Judgment Seat of Christ, a matter of reward, not of eternal life.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verses	Theme	Key truth
1:15–17	Christ and creation	He is God's image, preeminent Firstborn, Creator of all, and Sustainer of all.
1:18–20	Christ and the Church	He is Head, firstborn from the dead, the fullness of God, and Reconciler through the cross.
1:21–22	Christ and the cross	Alienated sinners are reconciled in His body through death,

Verses	Theme	Key truth
		to be presented holy and blameless.
1:23	The condition	Continuing steadfast in the faith governs the presentation, not the reconciliation.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · personal and corporate

1. Give Christ First Place

Scripture anchor: Colossians 1:18

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, II.B, and ② Devotional

God's purpose is that Christ "will come to have first place in everything." He already has first place in creation and in the resurrection. The question is whether He has first place in our schedules, our money, our relationships, and our thoughts.

Reflection: Where in your life does Jesus share first place with something else?

Practical step: Identify one area where Christ does not have first place and make one concrete change this week.

2. Rest in the One Who Holds Things Together

Scripture anchor: Colossians 1:17

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, I.D

When life feels like it is coming apart, remember that "in Him all things hold together." The same Lord who sustains galaxies sustains His people. Trust is not denial of trouble; it is confidence in the One who holds it.

Reflection: What feels most "unglued" in your life right now?

Practical step: Pray verse 17 over that situation each day, thanking Christ that He is holding it together.

3. Reconciled Now, Presented Then

Scripture anchor: Colossians 1:22–23; 2 Corinthians 5:10

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, III.C–D; cf. Dillow, The Reign of the Servant Kings (FGR)

Your reconciliation is settled. Nothing you do or fail to do can undo it. But the Lord also desires to present you holy, blameless, and beyond reproach, and that presentation depends on continuing steady in the faith. Assurance and accountability belong together: we serve not to be saved but because we are saved and will one day give an account.

Reflection: Is there anything currently moving you away from "the hope of the gospel"?

Practical step: Name one influence that weakens your steadiness in the faith and take one step to limit it this week.

End of Study · Colossians 1:15–23